Q. You talk of chess fondly, touching on beauty and aesthetics. But at just six-and-a-half years, what drew you to the game?
Before chess, we tried tennis, abacus and even skating. My family used to play chess as a hobby at home. I got interested in it and learned the rules. There was this summer camp in school when I was in the first standard and I tried out chess. There it was my first coach, Bhaskar Sir, who said I have a knack for it and should take it further. The thing is, chess had all these pieces, like toys, and I could just play around with them. Once I started to understand the rules, there was this unlimited beauty in chess. But I'm still learning...Vishy Sir has been playing for five decades and he is still learning every day.

Q. After becoming world champion, you said it doesn't mean you are the best in the world. Was that bait for world #1 Magnus Carlsen to get back to classical chess and play you?
It was a bit of both. At that point, I was being honest. It was clear that while the match was between two of the best players in the world, it was not a decider on who is the best. Some players believe that it should be. But when the best player doesn't want to play, it's not the fault of other players. As a chess fan, I'd love to see Magnus back.

Q. Commentators were struck by how often and long you keep your eyes shut in between moves. What was going on there?
Sometimes when I am calculating a position on the board, it is easier to visualise it with my eyes closed. But also sometimes when I am waiting for my opponent's counter and I know what I am going to play, there's no point in putting more energy into the moment. For the past few years, I have been doing meditation and yoga regularly. It's a core part of my mental and physical training now.

Q. To be No. 1, you'd need to enter the 2800 Elo rating club. Is that next on your target list?
This year it was all about the Candidates and the World Chess Championship. I was close to 2800 after the Olympiad but I don't think much about it. It's a special achievement and I am happy for Arjun [Erigaisi] who made it. It is one of my goals.

Q. Your specialty is classical chess, which some call the purest form of the game. When it looked like the World Championship match could go to a tie-break in rapid and blitz, many were seeing you as an underdog...

"It was clear that while the match was between two of the best players in the world, it was not a decider on who is the best. Some players believe it should be..."

I do want to improve in rapid and blitz. My results should have been better in the few tournaments [I played]. I have beaten Magnus in online rapid and freestyle. The way you approach games in rapid and blitz is different compared to classical but at the end of the day, it is still chess. I am more of a calculative player; in rapid and blitz, players who are intuitive tend to do well. But as a top-level chess player, you have to adapt.

Q. What do you make of India's Gen Z generation of players. Is there rivalry among you?
I mostly spend time with the guys. All of them are great players but I have to admit maintaining a relationship is tricky. I spend more time thinking about these guys than about family. We have good relations but I am not close to anyone...it's all ethical but minor details can be used against you. I respect them a lot.

Q. What impact has Vishy Sir had on your career?
Since the start, he has been a god figure and a huge inspiration. Since WACA (WestBridge Anand Chess Academy), we have been training together regularly. He was always there to analyse games, get on a call to discuss something. We can't thank Vishy Sir enough for the time he has given to the next generation. He helped me personally in getting Gayu (Polish GM Grzegorz Gajewski) to work exclusively as my coach.



VICTORY PARADE
Crowds line up to welcome Gukesh in hometown Chennai, Dec. 17